



UNIVERSITY OF GOTHENBURG

DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Guide

See Canvas for more detailed information!

SK 1136: Foreign Policy Analysis

7.5 Higher Education Credits

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Introduction

This course provides you with the key theoretical tools to interpret and explain how states – and increasingly, non-state actors – formulate and implement foreign policy. What shapes a state's foreign policy? How do factors like geography, political systems, leadership, and global power dynamics influence decision-making? How do states respond to crises, and what drives foreign policy change?

We will explore these questions through various theoretical perspectives and decision-making models, examining foreign policy at the individual, state, and systemic levels. While the state remains the central actor in our analysis, we also consider the growing influence of non-state actors like the European Union.

Teaching combines lectures and seminars. Lectures provide a foundation to the main concepts and theories of Foreign Policy Analysis. Seminars delve into specific case studies, offering opportunities for critical discussion and application of theoretical and conceptual perspectives.

This course guide outlines the expected learning outcomes, lecture and seminar topics, required readings, assessment methods, and participating teachers. The full schedule is found on Canvas.

Learning outcomes

On successful completion of the course, the student will be able to:

Knowledge and understanding

- Describe the basic theories about foreign policy at different levels-of-analysis (individual, state, system).
- Describe the foreign policy process and implementation from different decision-making models.
- Explain foreign policy change based on current academic research.
- Critically assess the role of the state in foreign policy and the rise of new non-state actors.
- Describe research designs and methods used in the course literature on foreign policy analysis.

Competence and skills

- Apply theories of foreign policy to empirical cases.
- Critically discuss and compare the explanatory power of different theories of foreign policy.
- Independently produce text in accordance with good academic practice, including proper citation technique and use of references.
- Summarize and present self-produced academic texts in a well-formulated and clear manner.
- Plan and work collectively in a group.
- Communicate clearly and proficiently in English both orally and in writing.

Judgement and approach

- Critically reflect on different foreign policy theories that are presented in the course literature and in lectures.
- Critically assess the research design and methods that is used on the course literature.

Teachers

- **Lisbeth Aggestam**, Associate Professor, lisbeth.agggestam@gu.se
- **Julian Walterskirchen**, Doctoral candidate, julian.walterskirchen@gu.se (Seminar 2).
- **Leonie Reicheneder**, Doctoral candidate, leonie.reicheneder@gu.se (Seminar 3).

Schedule

Changes of time or room might occur. Please see Canvas for updates.

Course literature

The core textbooks for this course are:

- S. Smith, A. Hadfield, T. Dunne and N. Kitchen , eds. (2024), *Foreign Policy: Theories, Actors, Cases*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 4th ed.
- K. Brummer and K. Oppermann (2024), *Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

For each lecture theme, you will find additional references to books and articles. These references will support you in reading more extensively on issues and subjects raised in the lectures and seminars and should be used as a reference source when you write your final essay. They are available to borrow or download online through the University of Gothenburg Library website. You should also search for academic texts beyond these readings for the seminar presentations. There are many excellent academic journals that publish on foreign policy, including, *Foreign Policy Analysis* (FPA), *International Affairs* (IA), *International Studies Quarterly* (ISQ), *International Security* (IS), *European Journal of International Relations* (EJIR).

Lectures

Lecture One

Introduction to Foreign Policy Analysis

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

This lecture provides you with an overview of what Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) is as a subfield within the study of international politics in political science, and elaborates on what the central analytical questions and topics are. The lecture will also include information about how the course is organized and assessed.

Required readings:

- Smith et al. (2024), *Foreign Policy*. Introduction + chapter 1. pp. 1-33.
- Brummer and Oppermann (2024). *Foreign Policy Analysis*. Chapter 1. pp. 1-16.

Supplementary readings:

- Kaarbo, J. and C. Thies (2024), Repositioning Foreign Policy Analysis in International Relations. in Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 1-24.

Lecture Two

Neoclassical realist theory: Bridging realism and liberalism in FPA

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

This lecture explores the two foundational traditions in Foreign Policy Analysis: realism and liberalism. Realism - historically a dominant force in international political theory - offers a state centric perspective of foreign policy, while liberalism considers a wider range of actors and emphasizes the importance of the domestic sources of foreign policy. Neoclassical realist theory serves as a bridge between these two traditions by integrating both the external constraints of the international system and the domestic factors shaping foreign policy outcomes.

Required readings:

- Brummer and Oppermann (2024), Chapters 2-3.
- L. Aggestam & A. Hyde-Price (2025). Crossing the Rubicon: Explaining Sweden's Decision to Join NATO. *The British Journal of Politics and International Relations*. 27(4): 1267-1291.
- Smith et al. (2024), Chapters 2-3. pp. 34-78.

Supplementary readings:

- G. Rose (1998) 'Review: Neoclassical Realism and Theories of Foreign Policy', *World Politics*, 51(1), pp. 144–172.
- A. Hadfield (2024), Foreign Policy Analysis and Liberalism. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Pp. 25-43.
- A. Wivel (2024), Foreign Policy Analysis and Realism. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. Pp. 971-114.

Lecture 3

Foreign policy decision-making

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

In this lecture, we will explore how decisions in foreign policy are made by examining foreign policy-making as a system composed of three stages: input (preferences), process (decision-making), and output (action and implementation). We will look at different theoretical approaches, such as the bureaucratic politics model and the cybernetic model, and consider the concept of 'bounded rationality,' which suggests that human decision-makers cannot always meet the ideal of perfectly rational choices. A central question we will address is whether foreign policy-making

can be accurately explained through rational choice theory, or whether these alternative models offer a more realistic framework for understanding and explaining how foreign policy decisions are reached.

Required readings:

- Smith et al. (2024), Chapters 8-9. pp. 147-179.
- Brummer and Oppermann (2024), Chapters 6-8.

Supplementary readings:

- D. P. Houghton (2024), Decision-making approaches and foreign policy-making. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp- 342-358.

Lecture 4

Leadership and foreign policy - The role of individuals

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

This lecture examines what role individual leaders play in foreign policy and discusses how, when and why they matter to foreign policy outcomes. We will discuss how leadership is defined and conceptualized in the FPA literature, particularly considering psychological approaches and leadership traits analysis.

Required readings:

- Brummer and Oppermann (2024), Chapters 10-11.
- S. B. Dyson (2024), Leader Psychology and Foreign Policy. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Supplementary readings:

- Kaarbo, J. and J. S. Lantis (2024), Executives and Foreign Policy. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Lecture 5

Societal Sources of Foreign Policy: Constructivism and Role Theory

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

This lecture looks inside the 'black box' of the state and examines how cultural norms, roles, and identities can influence both the process and substance of foreign policy-making, including the role of public opinion and organized interest groups. We will discuss constructivism and role

theory as tools of analysis to understand how these factors shape foreign policy preferences, decisions and outcomes.

Required readings:

- Smith et al. (2024), Chapters 4-5.
- M. Breuning (2024), National Roles and Foreign Policy. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp 211229.
- A. Julka (2024), Culture, Identity, and Foreign Policy. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 191210.

Supplementary readings:

- L. Aggestam, I. Schierenbeck, and A. Wackenhut (2023). Sweden, NATO and the Role of Diasporas in Foreign Policy. *International Affairs* 99(6): 2367-2385.
- P. A. Kowert and J. S. Barkin (2024), Foreign Policy Analysis and Constructivism. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 61-78.
- Brummer and Oppermann (2024), Chapter 4.
- E. K. Jenne and C. G. Thies (2024), Populism, Nationalism and Foreign Policy. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 229-248.

Lecture 6

Non-State Actors in Foreign Policy: The Case of the European Union

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

This lecture will examine the role of non-state actors, especially the emergence of the European Union (EU) as a new kind of foreign policy actor and discuss whether the process of Europeanization represents a significant transformation in the national foreign policy of individual EU member states.

Required readings:

- L. Aggestam (2024), The European Union: Building a Common Foreign Policy. In Smith, et al. pp. 392-412.
- K. Kille (2024), Foreign Policy of International Organizations. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 538-557.

Supplementary readings:

- S. Economides (2023), European Foreign policy and the Role of Member States: Europeanization or Renationalization?. In C. Hill, M. Smith and S. Vanhoonacker (eds.), *International Relations and the European Union*. 4th ed. pp. 91-110.
- A. Hadfield, I. Manners and R. Whitman, eds. (2017). *Foreign Policies of EU Member States: Continuity and Europeanization*. London: Routledge.

Lecture 7

Explaining Foreign Policy Change

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

The final lecture examines why and how foreign policies change over time. Different kinds of foreign policy change will be discussed: incremental adjustment, policy reversal, strategic reorientation, and paradigm shift. Drawing on the FPA theories we have covered throughout the course, we will discuss what the main drivers of foreign policy change are and consider whether some theories are better suited to explaining rapid versus gradual change.

Readings:

- J. Gustavsson (1999). How should we study foreign policy change? *Cooperation and Conflict* 34(1): 73-95.
- L. E. Wehner (2025). Gradual change in foreign policy: A Role-Theoretic Approach. *International Studies Perspectives*, doi.org/10.1093/isp/ekaf007.
- A. Michalski, D. Brommesson, A.-M. Ekengren (2024). Small states and the dilemma of geopolitics: Role change in Finland and Sweden. *International Affairs* 100(1): 139-157.

Supplementary readings:

- B. Martill and M. Sus (2024). Winds of change? Neoclassical realism, foreign policy change, and European responses to the Russia-Ukraine war. *The British Journal of Politics and International Relations*. 27(4): 129-1152.

Seminar Programme

This course has three mandatory seminars. In preparation of the seminar, you need to read the assigned literature listed in the seminar instructions and prepare supporting notes that you bring to the seminar so you can actively engage in the seminar discussion. You are also required to make a collective group presentation in one of the three seminars. Instructions can be found on Canvas for each of the three seminars. The groups will be organized in the first week of the course. The seminars are student-led and based on teamwork.

Seminar 1

Comparing Foreign Policy: Great Powers and Small States

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

In this seminar, you will be exploring how states navigate the complex realm of international relations, emphasizing the contrasting strategies and constraints faced by great powers and small states. By examining the driving forces behind foreign policy decisions, we will analyze and compare how historical, economic, political, and cultural factors shape the actions of states with different resources and ambitions. In this seminar, you will critically engage with case studies that span different regions, from the grand strategies of great powers to small state niche diplomacy. Through these comparisons, you will gain insights into the interplay of power, influence, and agency in foreign policy.

Required readings:

- S. Destradi and L. E. Wehner (2024), Foreign Policy of Emerging Powers. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 483-500.
- D. Panke and B. Thorhallsson (2024), Foreign Policy of Small States. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp.501-518.
- G. Giacomello and B. Verbeek (2024), Foreign Policy of Middle Powers. In Karbo and Thies (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Foreign Policy Analysis*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. pp. 519-537.

Supplementary readings:

- For case studies of specific countries – see Smith et al. (20024), Chapters 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 22.

Seminar 2

Foreign Policy Decision-Making in Crisis

Teacher: Lisbeth Aggestam

In this seminar, we will examine the three decision-making models (rational, organizational, governmental) that Graham Allison examined in his classic case study of the Cuban missile crisis. What are the key strengths and weaknesses of these models to explain decision-making in crisis? Are they competing or complementary? Can insights from the classic case study of the Cuban missile crisis be extrapolated to more current foreign policy crises?

Required readings:

- G. Allison (2024), The Cuban Missile Crisis. In Smith et al. pp. 271-300.
- Brummer and Oppermann (2024), The Group Think Model. Chapter 14. pp. 294-309.

- Stern, E. (2003), 'Crisis Studies and Foreign Policy Analysis: Insights, synergies and challenges, *Foreign Policy Analysis* 5(2): 155-202.
- Houghton, D. (2017). Crisis Decision Making in Foreign policy. *Oxford Research Encyclopaedias Politics*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190228637.013.403>

Seminar 3

Foreign Policy Beyond the State: Can the EU speak with 'one voice'?

Teacher: Leonie Reicheneder

The aim of this seminar is to critically assess whether the European Union can be considered a coherent foreign policy actor – and what it means, in practice, for the EU to 'speak with one voice.' To investigate this question, we examine EU policy towards two contrasting cases:

1. Russia's invasion and war in Ukraine, and
2. The Israeli–Palestinian conflict.

These two cases will allow students to evaluate the EU's foreign policy *actorness*, the degree of internal *coherence*, and the relative influence of EU institutions versus member states. Students will discuss how consensus is constructed, when and why it collapses, and whether variation across issue areas signals structural limitations to EU foreign policy.

Students should draw on the FPA theories covered in the course – including decision-making models, leadership and bureaucratic politics, domestic politics, identity-based approaches, and institutional/organisational theories – to explain why the EU appears unified on some policy issues yet fragmented in others.

Required readings:

- L. Aggestam and F. Bicchi (2019). New directions in EU foreign policy governance: Cross-loading, leadership and informal groupings. *Journal of Common Market Studies* 57(3): 515-532.
- C. Håkansson (2025). Understanding the European Union's Response to the Russian War in Ukraine: The Role of the European External Action Service. *Defence Studies*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14702436.2025.2562978>
- M. Riddervold and Pernille Rieker (2024). Coming of age? EU foreign and security policy after Ukraine. *European Security* 33(3): 497-516.

Supplementary reading:

- E. Conceicao-Heldt and S. Meunier (2014). Speaking with a single voice: internal cohesiveness and external effectiveness of the EU in global governance. *Journal of European Public Policy* 21(7): 961-979.

- S. Economides (2023), European Foreign policy and the Role of Member States: Europeanization or Renationalization?. In C. Hill, M. Smith and S. Vanhoonacker (eds.), *International Relations and the European Union*. 4th ed. pp. 91-110.
- A. Hadfield, I. Manners and R. Whitman, eds. (2017). *Foreign Policies of EU Member States: Continuity and Europeanization*. London: Routledge.

Assessment

The course is worth 7,5 higher education credits. There are three forms of assessments on this course, which must be completed in order to receive a pass for the entire course and to fulfil the learning outcomes. These consist of:

1. Active participation in three seminars (3 hec)
 2. An oral seminar presentation (1 hec)
 3. A written research essay of 3, 000 words (3,5 hec)
1. *Active seminar presentation:* There are three seminars on this course and participation is mandatory. You are required to actively prepare for and participate in all three seminars as outlined above. Each seminar is evaluated with the grade Pass or Fail.
 2. *Oral seminar presentation:* You will be required to make **one** oral seminar presentation on this course. In preparation for the seminar, you will be working with 3-4 students and prepare a collective group presentation lasting about 30 minutes based on the specific instructions for each seminar. The seminars are student-led and based on teamwork. The main responsibility for prompting an engaging seminar discussion lies with the presenters. Therefore, you need to plan the group presentation carefully and prepare questions for discussion. You are assigned a group at the start of the course. Based on an evaluation of your performance in the presentation, you will receive a Pass or Fail.
 3. *Written essay (3,000 words):* Towards the end of the course, you will be able to choose to write on a specific research topic that will allow you to deepen your knowledge of a particular research problem in Foreign Policy Analysis and demonstrate your ability to apply FPA theories to empirical cases. Detailed instructions can be found on Canvas.

The research essay should demonstrate a clear line of argument and critical reasoning around a specific research problem with consistent referencing (author, year, pages) to the course literature and other relevant academic sources. The essay should be clearly structured with an introduction, main text and conclusion. A complete bibliography should be included at the end of the essay.

Your paper is an individual piece of work that you are expected to write in your own words. AI-generated text is not allowed (see policy below) and you need to submit an AI-declaration on your

submitted work. All papers will be checked for plagiarism. The essay is assessed using the grades Fail, Pass, or Pass with Distinction.

Make-up Assignments for Missed Seminars

If you miss a seminar, you need to write and submit a make-up assignment that consist of writing a seminar paper of 1,500 words that demonstrates a critical engagement with the required seminar readings applying theory and concepts to relevant empirical events and cases following the seminar instructions. You upload your make-up assignment in the appropriate folder on Canvas. If you are unable to make an oral group presentation, you will be required to do an individual presentation recorded on Zoom – lasting around 10 minutes - and uploaded in the appropriate folder on Canvas.

Grading scale

The grading scale for this course is Fail (U), Pass (G), Pass with Distinction (VG).

- To obtain the Pass grade, the student must receive a Pass on all the three forms of assessment (oral presentation, active seminar participation, and written essay).
- To obtain Pass with Distinction for the entire course, a student must receive Pass with distinction (VG) on the written essay, providing evidence of an outstanding ability to connect FPA theories and concepts to empirical research findings with a high academic standard in terms of structure and language.

Academic Writing

The three hallmarks of good academic writing are clarity, precision, and intellectual honesty. Unlike some other forms of writing, academic texts should be free from ambiguity, and they should offer the reader plainly stated arguments, not rhetorical tricks. This does not mean that they have to be boring, of course, but it does mean that, whenever there is a conflict between being linguistically elegant and clear, the latter should take precedence. For example, in academic writing, it might be preferable to consistently use the same terms for the same concepts instead of using synonyms, even though this would be dull in other types of writing (such as fiction). To organize the text, a good rule of thumb is to make one point per paragraph.

Good academic writing is cumulative; it proceeds from, communicates with, and seeks to contribute to previous work on the topic of choice. It is essential that the author (or authors) gives due credit to previous work. There should never be any doubt as to whether segments of text, ideas, claims or results are the author's own or drawn from other sources. To ensure this, academic writing requires a transparent system of citation. Never 'copy and paste' text from other sources without citing those sources and enclosing direct quotes in quotation marks. Copying text without indicating it is a quotation constitutes plagiarism. Use references consistently and accurately. These requirements hold for all academic texts, from short student assignments and course papers to master theses and academic books and journal articles.

Here are two links that further describe the essentials of academic writing (please click “In English” in case the page appears in Swedish):

Searching and citing: <http://www.ub.gu.se/skriva/>

Tutorial in basic information seeking and information management:
<http://www.ub.gu.se/webbkurs/>

Language Support:

<http://studentportal.gu.se/english/help-and-guidance/language-support/faculty-of-social-sciences/?languageId=100001>

Information regarding how to write name etc. on take home exams/papers

Please add this information in the header on the first page of your papers/essays.

Last name:

First name:

Personal Number:

Course:

Part of Course:

Grading Teacher

Policies

Screen Use Policy: Screens and computers are permitted in class strictly for note-taking purposes. Research and experience show that the effectiveness of educational activities relies on collective attention. When someone uses a screen for unrelated activities, it distracts others and diminishes the overall learning experience.

AI policy: The use of generative AI tools (e.g., ChatGPT) for writing assignments is limited to brainstorming and outlining purposes only. Direct copying of AI-generated text is strictly prohibited, and AI must not be used for drafting or writing any part of the assignment. These assignments are designed to foster your critical thinking, analytical skills, and the ability to express original analysis and ideas. The purpose of this policy is to ensure the work remains your own and that you continuously practice your own skills in academic writing. **Please note** that the final assignment of the written research paper needs to include an **AI-declaration**.

Plagiarism: Academic writing is based on the principle of clarity and transparency regarding the source of the information and knowledge conveyed in the text. In academic writing, we use others' ideas, thoughts, arguments, opinions, and conclusions, but we make the origin of these clear by citing and referencing. We rely on, communicate with, build upon, and credit previous research,

authors, and sources—but we do NOT copy them! Copying is plagiarism, i.e., cheating. You can read more on academic writing and plagiarism on the Canvas course page. The Department of Political Science uses sophisticated plagiarism detection systems. Teachers are also skilled at detecting texts that are not independently written through critical reading. We are obliged to report suspected cheating to the Disciplinary Board at GU. Cheating can result in a warning or suspension from the program.

Read more on plagiarism at GU's student portal.

Equal Treatment: The University of Gothenburg aims to promote equal rights and opportunities for students and employees and to combat discrimination related to gender, gender identity or gender expressions, ethnicity, religion or other beliefs, sexual orientation, disability or age. If, however, you as a student at the Department of Political Science become subject to such acts and actions, we encourage you to contact us to enable the opportunity for appropriate action. You can contact: the course coordinator, Director of studies Birgitta Niklasson, Equal treatment representative Ulrika Möller, or Student counselor Eva Nilsson. Student counselors have confidentiality. You can also turn to these persons if you experience problems or discomfort in the study environment, even if not targeted at you. Contact information is available on our website.